cook and astrologer, but no time was set aside for family and progeny. One imagines that the sixth part of the day, when he could ‘engage in recreation at his pleasure’,[49] refers to activities quite far removed from a devoted enlarging of the minds of children.

Proper arrangements were of course put in place within the palace for the education of princes. A general sense of their upbringing can be had from the section in the *Arthashastra* which sets out how princes were to be trained. Unlike Egypt, where we see Cleopatra employing a distinguished scholar of Damascus to educate her twins, Alexander Helios and Cleopatra Selene, in the court of the Mauryas the princesses were not thought worthy of an education.[50] No source says anything about Ashoka’s sisters. Ashoka himself was likely to have been raised, like his male siblings, to be an effective leader and administrator. A prince’s training ranged from the martial arts to more cerebral subjects. In his early childhood, probably at the age of 3, he would have been tonsured, and then instructed in writing and arithmetic. After his initiation (‘upanayana’), he is likely to have had several tutors because he was expected to ‘learn the three Vedas and philosophy from the learned, economics from the heads of departments (and) the science of politics from theoretical and practical exponents.’[51] The training was continuous, conducted daily. In the first part of the day the subject of study was how to use elephants, horses, chariots, and weapons; in the latter part the prince was expected to listen to what is described as ‘itihasa’. This denotes ‘history’ in our time, but in Ashoka’s it covered a range of knowledge about the world. A prince listening to ‘itihasa’ would have acquired narrative histories of the universe, economics, and the existing ideas about social functioning.[52]

One may reasonably assume that the range of able officials in the court of Bindusara included tutors designated for such work. A minister-in-charge of the princes was, we know, expected to live in the palace.[53] That Ashoka was well taught is evident from the fact that his inscriptions reflect a deep